killed in the campaign. Several towns and 90 per cent of all villages were destroyed. Millions of land mines were planted, especially in the border areas.

Discontent and unrest in Iraq

Key question
Why was there discontent in Iraq?

Even after a long war with Iran and despite huge debts, Saddam continued to build up his military machine and develop the most modern weapons. Yet the economy was in tatters and there was no post-war recovery: the value of Iraq's oil exports had declined because of war damage and a fall in the oil prices on the world market. Many people in the oil industry lost their jobs and, to make matters worse, thousands of soldiers were demobilised, thus adding to mounting unemployment.

Despite the terror exercised by Saddam's police and army, there were riots and strikes, some co-ordinated in the mosques which were beyond the control of Saddam's police and army. The army would not dare to attack the mosques, the most holy places, because it would intensify the opposition of all Muslims. But the main threat to Saddam came from his army. Many officers felt cheated of victory over Iran and some privately blamed Saddam for the failure to defeat their neighbour. There were several attempts to overthrow him between 1988 and 1990 and many officers were executed for conspiracy. Saddam needed to divert attention away from a growing military crisis in Baghdad. This may have been one of the reasons for the invasion of Kuwait.

The question of Kuwait

Key question
Why did Saddam Hussein invade Kuwait?

In the early twentieth century Kuwait was a small, insignificant fishing village at the southern end of the Turkish empire (see the map on page 131). The Turks planned to make it part of the Turkish province of Basra but the British intervened and signed a treaty with the main tribal leader to protect the independence of Kuwait. After the First World War and the defeat of Turkey, the British decided on, and then imposed, the borders of Iraq. These excluded Kuwait from Iraq.

The new Iraqi government refused to recognise the border with Kuwait, claiming that Iraq needed a safe outlet to the sea and that there were historic ties between Kuwait and Basra. In fact, many Kuwaitis had trade links with Basra and owned property there: for instance, the ruler of Kuwait, the Emir, owned more property in Basra than in Kuwait itself. Furthermore, many Kuwaitis wanted to be part of Iraq. They felt that they would be more secure as part of a wealthier, stronger country, especially as they feared their big Saudi neighbour. But then oil was discovered in Kuwait and neither the Kuwaitis nor their British protectors wanted to share it.

In the early 1960s, when the British recognised the full independence of Kuwait and planned to remove their troops, Iraq declared that Kuwait was a part of their country and claimed supreme power over it. The Arab League decided to send troops to protect Kuwait. In 1963, Iraq recognised Kuwait's independence but there continued to be tensions over the border.